Once again, the different lessons learned from the Second World War played a role in shaping US and Indian views of the best approach. Henderson told Bajpai that collective failure to combat aggression would only lead to more belligerence, eventually resulting in a larger war.[215] A frustrated Acheson could not understand "what means India would propose [to] use to check aggression" instead.[216] Bajpai contended that the means would "depend upon form and character of aggression and upon effect which such means might have upon world peace."[217]

The differences over means, including the right balance between the use of force and diplomacy, were broader. NSC-68 and subsequent American policy reflected the belief that the need to counter an existential threat did not just make "all interests vital"; it also made "all means affordable, all methods justifiable." But for Nehru, as the Australian high commissioner to India put it, "the end rarely justified the means." In the US, moreover, the Korean War had only strengthened the view expressed in NSC-68 that active military resistance was more appropriate than passively waiting for the emergence of nationalist resistance—as Nehru seemed to prefer. These different views of the best means were perhaps partly influenced by the two countries' capabilities. While there was a sense in the Truman administration that rather than divide the resource pie, one could expand it to justify larger defense spending, Indian policymakers, including Nehru, did not believe that was feasible for them given their limited resources.[218]

Henderson hoped that differences over tactics would not overpower a common interest in peace and security.[219] But for Acheson, "it was not [Nehru's] objectives so much as [the] way in which he said and did things which had caused us lots of trouble."[220] Nehru, too, subsequently acknowledged that the main difference between the US and India was "in the method of approach."[221] For US policymakers "frustrating the Kremlin design" had become a goal in itself.[222] For Nehru, this blurring of means and ends—and the American emphasis on military instruments—made it harder to achieve the objective of peace.

The consequence of these differences, especially as the situation in Korea deteriorated after the Chinese intervention, was strain in the US-India relationship. Pandit expressed concern to Bajpai about the "considerable hostility" toward India in US government circles as a result of various China-related disagreements. Lamenting "the universality of the change in